BONUS 1

Iron Posture Protocol



A sequence to align your spine and relieve the tension of sitting all day.

WALL PILATES · 21-DAY CHALLENGE

Why posture changes your body

Spending hours sitting, looking at your phone or computer, pulls your shoulders forward, closes your chest and pushes your head forward. Over time, your chest muscles shorten, your back muscles get weak and your lower back and neck work harder than they should. The result is that heavy-body feeling, pain at the end of the day and a belly that looks bigger than it really is.

The good news: posture is a habit. With **10 minutes a day** of wall exercises and a few simple tweaks to your routine, you teach your body to stay aligned effortlessly.

> **How to use this protocol**
>
> Do the **Iron Posture Routine** every day for 4 weeks, ideally in the morning or right after work. On 21-Day Challenge days, you can do it before your workout as a warm-up. Use the **micro-breaks** throughout the day.

The wall test: your starting point

1. Stand with your heels a hand-width from the wall.
2. Press your hips, back and, if you can without forcing, the back of your head against the wall.
3. Notice: does your head touch without lifting your chin? Do your shoulders touch the wall?
4. Slide your hand between your lower back and the wall: a flat hand should fit, not a closed fist.

Write down how the test went today and repeat it at the end of each week. It's the simplest way to see your progress.

The Iron Posture Routine (10 minutes)

Do them in order, without rushing

1	Lateral breathing against the wall	1 minute
2	Standing cat-cow at the wall	8 reps
3	Wall angels	2 sets of 8
4	Wall thoracic rotation	6 per side
5	Standing chest opener (wall swan)	8 reps
6	Pelvic tilt with feet on the wall	10 reps
7	Incline wall plank	3 x 20 seconds
8	Wall chest stretch	30 seconds per side

Rest 15 to 20 seconds between exercises.

The exercises, step by step

Lateral breathing against the wall

1 minute

Diaphragm · Intercostals · Transverse abdominis

Position: Sitting on the mat, back against the wall, legs crossed or extended.

1. Rest your whole back on the wall and lengthen the crown of your head toward the ceiling.
2. Place your hands on the sides of your ribs.
3. Breathe in through your nose, expanding your ribs sideways into your hands.
4. Breathe out slowly through your mouth, feeling your belly button draw toward your spine.

Breathing: Inhale for 4 counts, exhale for 6 counts. The exhale is always longer.

Avoid: Lifting your shoulders as you inhale. Pushing out only your belly instead of opening your ribs.

Easier version: Do it sitting in a chair with your back against the wall.

Safety: If you feel dizzy, go back to breathing normally for a few cycles.

Standing cat-cow at the wall

8 reps

Upper and lower spine | Abs | Chest

Position: Standing, facing the wall, hands on it at shoulder height, one step back.

1. Feet hip-width apart, knees slightly bent.
2. Round your back, drawing your belly button in and looking toward it (cat).
3. Then open your chest, bringing your breastbone toward the wall (cow).
4. Alternate smoothly, without rushing.

Breathing: Exhale as you round, inhale as you open your chest.

Avoid: Moving only your neck. Locking your knees.

Easier version: Do it seated with your hands on your knees if standing is tiring.

Safety: Keep the movements within a pain-free range.

Wall angels

2 sets of 8

Middle and lower trapezius | Rhomboids | Chest (stretch)

Position: Standing, back against the wall, feet one step forward, knees slightly bent.

1. Press your hips, back and, if possible, your head against the wall.
2. Bend your elbows to 90° with your arms and backs of your hands on the wall, making a "W".
3. Slide your arms up without losing contact with the wall.
4. Slide back down to the "W", squeezing your shoulder blades together.

Breathing: Inhale as your arms go up, exhale as they come down.

Avoid: Arching your lower back to keep your arms on the wall. Shrugging your shoulders toward your ears.

Easier version: Move your arms a few inches off the wall and reduce the range.

Safety: Stop if you feel tingling in your arms or shoulder pain.

Pain or limitations in your shoulders? Swap for: Wall chest stretch.

Wall thoracic rotation

6 per side

Upper spine | Obliques | Chest

Position: Standing sideways to the wall, an arm's length away, arms extended in front with palms together on the wall.

1. Keep your hips facing forward.
2. Open your outer arm in an arc, rotating your chest, until your hand touches the wall behind you (or as far as is comfortable).
3. Follow your hand with your eyes.
4. Come back slowly and repeat. Then switch sides.

Breathing: Inhale as you open, exhale as you return.

Avoid: Rotating your hips too. Forcing your shoulder at the end of the movement.

Easier version: Only open halfway.

Safety: The twist comes from your mid-back, not your lower back.

Standing chest opener (wall swan)

8 reps

Spinal extensors | Chest (stretch) | Shoulders

Position: Facing the wall, hands on it at chest height, one step back.

1. Slide your hands up the wall.
2. Gently bring your chest toward the wall, opening your upper back.
3. Come back by sliding your hands down.

Breathing: Inhale as you open, exhale as you return.

Avoid: Bending only at your lower back. Throwing your head back.

Easier version: Keep your hands lower.

Safety: The opening comes from your mid-back; your abs protect your lower back.

Pelvic tilt with feet on the wall

10 reps

Transverse abdominis | Rectus abdominis | Pelvic floor

Position: Lying on your back, hips close to the wall, knees bent at 90° and feet resting on the wall.

1. Start with a neutral spine: a small space between your lower back and the floor.
2. As you exhale, tuck your pelvis so your lower back touches the floor.
3. As you inhale, slowly return to neutral.
4. Keep your feet pressing lightly and steadily into the wall.

Breathing: Exhale as you tuck your pelvis, inhale as you return.

Avoid: Using your glutes to push instead of your abs. Holding your breath.

Easier version: Make the movement smaller: even a tiny tilt activates your deep core.

Safety: The movement should feel comfortable for your lower back; don't force the range.

Incline wall plank

3 x 20 seconds

Transverse abdominis | Rectus abdominis | Shoulders | Glutes

Position: Forearms on the wall at shoulder height, feet away from it.

1. Walk your feet back until your body forms an inclined line.
2. Elbows under shoulders, abs tight and glutes engaged.
3. Hold the position without letting your lower back sag.

Breathing: Steady lateral breathing; don't hold your breath.

Avoid: Hips too high. Shrugged shoulders.

Easier version: Move your feet closer to the wall so you're more upright.

Safety: If you feel it in your lower back, move your feet closer and brace your abs.

Wall chest stretch

30 seconds per side

Pectoralis major and minor | Front deltoid

Position: Standing sideways to the wall, forearm on it with your elbow at shoulder height.

1. Rest your palm and forearm on the wall.
2. Take a small step forward with the foot on the same side.
3. Gently turn your chest away until you feel a stretch in the front of your shoulder.
4. Hold, then switch sides.

Breathing: Breathe deeply and exhale slowly, relaxing your shoulder with each exhale.

Avoid: Lifting your shoulder. Turning too far and feeling pain instead of a stretch.

Easier version: Place your arm lower, below shoulder height.

Safety: A stretch is a gentle pulling sensation, never sharp pain.

4-week plan

Week	What to do	Focus
1	Full routine once a day, at the slowest pace	Learn the moves and notice your breathing
2	Full routine + 3 micro-breaks a day	Bring good posture to work and your phone
3	Routine with a 30 s plank + 4 micro-breaks	Strength to hold your alignment
4	Routine with 3 sets of angels + 5 micro-breaks	Automatic posture, without having to think

1-minute micro-breaks

Set an alarm every 1 or 2 hours. When it goes off, pick one:

- **Chin tucks:** seated, draw your chin back as if making a "double chin". Hold 3 s and release. 8 times.
- **Shoulders back and down:** roll your shoulders back 5 times and finish with your shoulder blades "in your back pockets".
- **Doorway chest opener:** forearms on the door frame, step forward and take 3 breaths.
- **Get up and walk:** 1 minute of walking, looking at the horizon, not the floor.
- **4–6 breathing:** inhale for 4 counts, exhale for 6. Three rounds.

Tweaks that change your day

- **Phone at eye level:** bring the phone up to your face, not your face down to the phone.
- **Computer screen:** top of the screen at eye level and an arm's length away.
- **Chair:** feet flat on the floor, hips all the way back and a small cushion behind your lower back.
- **Purse:** switch shoulders or choose a backpack with both straps.
- **Sleep:** on your side with a pillow between your knees; or on your back with a pillow under your knees.
- **Lifting things:** bend your knees, keep the object close to your body and exhale as you lift.

Daily checklist

- [ ] I did the Iron Posture Routine
- [ ] I held my phone at eye level
- [ ] I did the wall test (end of the week)
- [ ] I took at least 3 micro-breaks
- [ ] I drank water throughout the day

This material is educational and does not replace guidance from a doctor, dietitian or certified fitness professional. If you have any health condition, are pregnant, postpartum or feel pain, talk to a professional before starting and always respect your body's limits.